

An employee complies with a supervisor's request to engage in behavior that the employee knows is unethical. Does this scenario illustrate obedience?

- ☐ A. Yes, because the employee experiences peer pressure to act in order to be accepted. [8%]
- ✓ ☒ B. Yes, because the employee occupies a position of lower status than the supervisor. [85%]
- ☐ C. No, because complying with requests from a supervisor is part of the employee's social role. [4%]
- ☐ D. No, because the employee would be able to deflect blame onto the supervisor.

Correct

85% answered correctly

Explanation:

Factors correlated with increased obedience	
Personal factors	• Status: lower status, less power
Situational factors	• Proximity: authority figure is closer, victim is farther away • Legitimacy: authority figure seems more legitimate, prestigious • Consensus: everyone else is obeying
Cultural factors	• Collectivism: societies that value the group over the individual

Obedience is a type of **conformity** in which an individual carries out **orders** given by an **authority figure**. Research on obedience suggests that people tend to obey even when doing so results in immoral or unethical behavior.

Conducted in the 1960s, Stanley Milgram's landmark obedience study demonstrated that most people will deliver dangerously high electric shocks to a confederate posing as a research participant if commanded to do so by the researcher (an authority figure).

An employee complying with a supervisor's request to engage in behavior that the employee knows is unethical would be an example of obedience because the employee (lower status than the supervisor) is carrying out the orders of the supervisor (authority figure).

(Choice A) Peer pressure occurs when individuals experience social influences that persuade them to conform to group norms in order to be accepted. Even though it is possible that this employee feels peer pressure, the experience of peer pressure does not make this an example of *obedience*.

(Choice C) Social roles include the behaviors, beliefs, and norms that accompany a socially defined position. Even though complying with requests from a supervisor is part of the employee's social role, engaging in behavior that is unethical based on the *command of an authority figure* still illustrates obedience.

(Choice D) Even though the employee could blame the supervisor for the unethical behavior, this scenario still illustrates obedience to authority. In fact, the ability to defer blame to an authority figure *increases* the likelihood that an individual will obey.

Educational objective:

Obedience to authority is a type of conformity in which an individual carries out the orders of an authority figure, even when doing so results in immoral or unethical behavior.

Time spent:0 sec

Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

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System:
Identity and Social Interaction